

industry has undertaken substantial investments to enhance its capacity. The continuation of private capital expenditure will be jeopardised without favourable margins. Essential for this is a continued supportive environment and policy backing from the government.

While the confidence of international investors is boosting the sector's firmness, it is grappling with rising imports as a critical challenge. The recent surge in imports, coupled with high raw material costs, has hampered opportunities for domestic steel producers. Capping imports and prioritising domestic production are not just essential, it is an imperative step towards self-sufficiency. Beyond import substitution, the goal must be to supply steel to the world. We must carve our niche in high-value-added steel products and further integrate into the global value chain. Bridging the gap with China, the world's largest steel producer, requires long-term strategic action.

STEEL REIMAGINED

The future of steel lies in constant evolution towards India's net-zero goal of 2070. Technology is transforming this metal into smarter steel, which will be at the forefront of solving new-age solutions for contemporary challenges, including environmental issues and sector-specific demands such as automotive, solar, and mega structures. The world is pushing for a greener future. There is a need to

invest in the latest technologies that reduce CO₂ emissions, conserve energy, and optimise resource utilisation. Producing low-carbon steel would increase the cost of production by 20% compared to conventional methods. However, with breakthrough technologies and scale achievement, the production cost will drop.

Therefore, it is important that

BUILDING THE WORK-FORCE OF TOMORROW

Technology is powerful, but it needs a skilled workforce to use it. Steel manufacturers are increasingly adopting artificial intelligence, robotics, digitalisation, and Internet of Things solutions to transform their facilities into smart factories that strive to optimise operations, improve safety,

reduce costs, and meet climate action goals. The industry is firmly committed to upskilling and reskilling our workforce, equipping them with the expertise to handle the complexities of tomorrow's steel industry.

TRANSFORMATION TOWARDS SMARTER STEELS

The next five years will be vital for the transformation of India's steel industry. We, as responsible corporate citizens, are ready to play our part, forging

a future where steel not only fuels our economic engine but also lays the foundation for a self-reliant, sustainable, and technologically advanced India, which needs smarter steels that can create brighter futures. **BT**

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ILLUSTRATION BY RAJ VERMA



the government create an ecosystem for technological growth. Plans to set up a carbon trading system in the country are also a step in the right direction. The power cost accounts for 70% of the production cost of hydrogen. For green hydrogen, renewable power is the energy source. To make hydrogen affordable, the renewable energy cost must come down.